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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1966

Coverage Date: 1950-1966

Place Coverage

G/wi, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S): SOCIAL CONTROL

Outside the nuclear family, then, authority is ephemeral, rising to deal with specific situations, with power exercised by persuasion, and lapsing again when the response has been executed. Authority lacks any institutionalized recognition and is rewarded only by the continuation of the group's activities and attainment of its goals and, perhaps, by the personal satisfaction of the exercise of skill. In the randomly selected population of the band there is a limited proportion of members who possess the attributes of even this ephemeral leadership; it is thus inevitable that the same individuals repeatedly come forward to deal with situations in which particular ability is required. This does not lead to a centralizing of authority in them nor to the ascription of power to them. Each of these initiators or proposers operates in a limited field of activities; in these he acquires the prestige needed to persuade the group to his point of view more easily, but this power does not overflow into any other field of action.

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In this climate of limited personal power and authority, the real power and authority reside in the community as a whole, that is, in public opinion. The absence in the band of strongly cohesive units larger than the nuclear family makes it necessary to canvass each band member in order to mobilize public opinion. Even within a nuclear family, the status of husband and wife are on terms of equality, which precludes any prediction that a husband or wife will follow the lead of the other, and the household cannot, therefore, be regarded as one unit of opinion. In the intimate social life of the band, with its high rate of interaction between members, there is constant awareness of everybody's business, so the mobilization of public opinion by gossip, aided by the uninhibited comment of joking partners, is very effective. In this sensitive environment conflict and tension are detected early in their development and countermeasures can be taken before a matter becomes serious and escapes

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the rather weak means of control which are available to a community in which there is no one voice of authority. It is not possible for this observer to measure the efficacy of resolution of conflict in its initial stages, since the potential seriousness of situations cannot be reliably predicted. However, some impression may be gained from the rarity of conflicts which progress as far as the public scene of "talking at," in which an aggrieved member airs his difference with another by expounding his grievance to a third party in the hearing of the whole band. His adversary, if he has an answer,  318 pleads his case to a fourth party. In most instances the band comes to judgment after hearing the opening pleas, and, by interjections and comments, band members indicate their views of the matter. The offender sees his fault and comes to the aggrieved colleague and apologizes or makes other reparation, thus ending the affair.

Informal In-Group
Justice

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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